

Chapter 100 - Transgression

Though this kiss was like a dragonfly touching water, touching and immediately leaving, it was enough to cause both their hearts to simultaneously fall into thunderous turmoil.

The faint salty taste of tears lingered around her nostrils. Su Mo felt electric currents surge through her limbs and bones, the currents gathering from all over her body into her heart, making her instantly panic and retreat using both hands and feet.

Ning Fuyi realized what she had done and hurriedly reached out to grab her dress hem. However, that silky fabric slipped from her palm like a fish entering water, and in the blink of an eye, it had crossed over the collapsed courtyard wall and headed down the mountain slope.

Su Mo fled in panic, her waterfall-like long hair rising and falling in waves behind her. Then came the slam of a door. Even across a mountain slope, Ning Fuyi could almost hear the huge sound of the door colliding with its frame.

She slowly withdrew her hand and placed it on her heart, gripping her clothing tightly, her eyes downcast and lost in thought.

On the other side, after Su Mo forcefully shut the door, she pressed herself against the wall. Her forehead felt burning and painful. She frantically searched for a bronze mirror and held it up to the light to look at herself. After seeing her face full of red flush, she forcefully threw the mirror back into the distance.

With a loud thud, she couldn't hear it.

The fear from being frightened by the large beast had already been replaced by panic. Su Mo forcefully rubbed her cheeks several times but didn't wipe away the sensation on her lips.

The woman's kiss was more gentle than she herself appeared to be, like a flower petal that fell on one's lips when waking from a nap in the courtyard in spring.

Fragrant and warm.

After being dazed for a while, Su Mo suddenly realized that she was actually savoring the taste of that kiss, so she covered her face again and spun around the room twice before sitting heavily on the bed in frustration.

However, her thoughts had already become sticky and sweet, not under her control.

When her parents were alive, they had thought about finding her a good family that wouldn't mind her birthmark. However, yin-yang eyes¹ were almost equivalent to evil spirits in people's minds. After testing several people's reactions, they finally gave up on this idea.

Su Mo herself had never harbored such delusions. When her parents were alive, she only wanted to learn medical skills and pharmacology well, thinking that she could save more people in the future to atone for her sins, so that her next life would be better. After her parents died, she was busy day and night trying to pay off debts, never having time to think about such things.

Moreover, with her conditions, there were very few good people willing to approach her. That fellow Qin Xiaoran² had only glimpsed half her face by accident, which stirred his interest - she never took it seriously.

So even though she found herself increasingly dependent on this woman of unknown origin, she never dared to think about it in any other way, especially since she was also a woman like herself.

So even if there were occasional moments of attraction, there was always an invisible wall between them that she dared not cross.

However, the woman's action just now had, in her moment of unpreparedness, destroyed that wall completely.

Just as Su Mo's heart was in chaos, the light spots filtering through the window lattice below her feet suddenly flickered bright and dark. She quickly looked up and saw a completely snow-white dove hitting the window with its head - bang, bang, bang.

She hurriedly got up to open the window. The dove flew dizzily to land on her fingertip, properly lifting one foot.

Su Mo carefully removed the message tube from beside the dove's foot, opened it to read the writing inside, and her eyebrows showed some joy.

Then she stood by the window to calm down for a while before putting on her face veil, opening the door, and walking quickly toward the town.

Though the town was small, it was quite lively when it wasn't the rainy season. The riverbanks on both sides were bustling with activity, with many teahouses open. Several idle people sat under shade canopies, drinking tea with the gentle breeze.

Su Mo's veil fluttered lightly as she shielded herself from the scorching sun with one hand and walked to the end of the riverbank. She entered a bookstore³ with familiarity. There were few people in the bookstore, and no one paid attention to her, so she lifted her skirt and silently went up to the second floor.

The second floor was where people lived. Upon entering, the air was filled with ink fragrance. A person sat by the window reading in the natural light. Looking up to see her enter, they joyfully put down their book and stood up.

"I've been waiting for you for a long time." That person was a woman, about the same age as Su Mo. Her every movement carried a scholar's dignity, quite out of place with the tea-fragrant busy street. "Would you like some tea?"

Su Mo shook her head and urgently gestured: "Where's the bird?"

"Wow, we haven't seen each other for a year and you don't greet me at all, only caring about your bird." The woman smiled and shook her head, then turned to take a birdcage from outside the window and handed it to her.

"This time I went to the capital to find that famous veterinarian, but he said your parrot's lifespan is naturally short to begin with. Being able to live to this age is already quite elderly. He fed it some medicine and said it can live at most one more year." The woman's smile faded as she regretfully reached through the cage bars to play with the bird.

In the cage was a bright yellow parrot with a blue beak in a beautiful curved hook shape. Seeing Su Mo, it excitedly flapped its wings.

A flash of grief passed through Su Mo's eyes, but it quickly dissipated. She hurriedly opened the cage and let the parrot jump onto her shoulder.

"One year is good too." Su Mo smiled, then tilted her head to let the parrot nuzzle against her ear.

"Better than nothing." The woman smiled, sat back in her chair, and picked up her book again.

After Su Mo finished being affectionate with the bird, she carefully looked at the woman and gently gestured: "How are you? Did you pass the imperial examination?"

"How could that be possible? Although I entered the metropolitan examination⁴, I was discovered halfway through and thrown out of the examination hall on the spot. If that literary official hadn't taken pity on my talent, you and I would have met in prison." The woman spoke casually with a light smile, as if this matter was nothing to her.

"Sigh, I just don't understand - we're all human, so why can't women, no matter how talented, take the examinations for official positions? I was first place in the provincial examination, yet they threw me out just like that." The woman tapped her head with her book, but her face showed no signs of struggle.

Su Mo was silent for a long while before raising her hands again: "What will you do in the future?"

"If this place won't keep me, there will be other places that will." The woman shook her hair ornament, reciting like reading a book, then smiled broadly: "I heard that the distant Qi Kingdom⁵ doesn't restrict women from entering government service, and their emperor is an empress. So after this year, I plan to go to Qi Kingdom. I don't believe I won't be able to pass the examinations there."

"Qi Kingdom?" Su Mo's eyes widened.

The woman nodded without saying more, but suddenly noticed something and tilted her head to stare at Su Mo.

After a moment, she raised her eyebrows: "I feel you've changed greatly since returning this time. There's less fear in your expression, and you don't even dodge when I'm this close to you?"

"You know, although we've known each other since childhood, you've always been taciturn and full of wariness, not peaceful like you are now." The woman leaned forward and put down her book scroll, studying her inquisitively.

Su Mo was reminded of the scene from earlier, and the skin under her veil heated up again. Fortunately, it was concealed and wouldn't be discovered.

She lowered her eyes and struggled for a while. Since childhood, she couldn't see people and could only study flowers and plants in her courtyard by herself. Only the young lady from the neighboring courtyard occasionally climbed over the wall to chat with her briefly.

Although she never responded, the other party was too persistent, so she occasionally replied with a few gestures in sign language.

She initially thought the other party couldn't understand her gestures and would soon get bored, but unexpectedly, after a few days, the young lady had taught herself sign language and spoke with her even more enthusiastically. Over time, they became familiar with each other, and she learned that the young lady's surname was Qi, named Qi Yunlou⁶.

Qi Yunlou was completely opposite to her - she was free-spirited and gentle, seeming to have no fear of anything and disregarding others' words with disdain.

This person was the only one she was familiar with in the world, and she was a good person.

Seeing her lower her eyes without speaking, Qi Yunlou's curiosity grew even stronger. She turned to go to the neighboring teahouse to get a pot of spring tea and turnip cake, placing them on the table: "Talk, talk, talk. You and I have been neighbors for many years - if not friends, at least acquaintances. Maybe if you tell me, I can help you a bit?"

Su Mo couldn't resist her persistence and could only hesitantly take a seat.

After a while, she finally lowered her aching hands and fearfully looked up to see Qi Yunlou's reaction.

She saw that Qi Yunlou's expression was normal, her brows tightly furrowed, her fingers calloused from writing resting on her chin, as if thinking about something.

Could she also find this matter strange? Although Miss Qi was learned, she also studied the ways of the ancients, so she must also have some criticism of this matter..

Thinking of this, Su Mo's face was already completely red. Just as she was about to get up and take her leave, she saw Qi Yunlou slap her palm heavily on the table edge. Looking up, her face was full of spring joy: "At first, hearing what you said, I thought the other party was being improper. Now it seems you indeed feel differently about her? Although this girl is mysterious, she seems like a good person. If you really have feelings for her, you might as well give it a try!"

Su Mo was stunned and couldn't help but loosen the dress corners she had been gripping, raising her hand to shake her head: "But, but with my background, and that Taoist said I wouldn't live past twenty-three years. If I really... wouldn't that harm her?"

Qi Yunlou smiled and waved her hand: "You're like my parents - when you want to do something, you're always hesitant and think too much. I'm different from you all; I never like to complicate matters when dealing with things."

"The other party was indeed improper first in this matter. If you rejected her, you would have directly slapped her just now. If you don't reject her, then tell her your doubts clearly. If she minds, she'll naturally leave. If she doesn't mind, then wouldn't everyone be happy?"

"You're keeping your thoughts from the other party, making it difficult for both yourself and her - why do this? I know you're someone who always considers others, but being a bit selfish sometimes isn't a bad thing." Qi Yunlou wasn't exactly earnestly advising, just speaking in a joking manner.

Su Mo blinked, seeming to be conflicted.

"Su Mo, actually, from the first moment I saw you, I wanted to become close friends with you, but you never gave me the chance." Qi Yunlou smiled like bright spring sunshine.

"Perhaps there really is such a thing as fate in the world, or perhaps I always feel that you're much more resilient and brave than you appear on the surface, living like mountain grass - wildfire cannot burn it all, spring wind blows and it grows again⁷."

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The sky darkened. Boats passing on the river hung lanterns, floating past one by one on the dark water surface. The teahouses closed early, and the aroma of various families' meals drifted from stove chimneys, gathering in reunion above the town.

Su Mo walked out of the bookstore carrying a birdcage, looking up at the sky wrapped in white clouds. The fragrance of food and the crisp scent of river water entered through her nose, making her stomach growl.

She touched the chirping bird and turned around against the evening wind. However, her heart jumped when she saw the person standing under the teahouse flag across the street.

The woman didn't know how long she had been standing there. Her shoulders were already damp, her black hair and black clothes hanging quietly together, as if merging with the night.

Su Mo immediately felt nervous. She unconsciously smoothed her dress hem and mustered the courage to step forward.

"Why did you find this place?" Su Mo raised her hand.

"I was afraid you were in danger, so I followed." Ning Fuyi answered truthfully, her voice very low. "Just now I was transgressing again."

Su Mo raised her face and shook her head. She reached out from her sleeve, seeming to want to place it in Ning Fuyi's palm, but withdrew it fearfully when she was about to touch.

"I have something to tell you." She gestured.

"Mm, as do I." Ning Fuyi said.

Footnotes:

1. **Yin-yang eyes (阴阳眼)** - The supernatural ability to see spirits and ghosts, considered both a gift and a curse in Chinese folklore.
2. **Qin Xiaoran (秦啸然)** - A minor character mentioned earlier who had shown interest in Su Mo.
3. **Bookstore (书祠)** - Literally "book heir," referring to a traditional bookstore that often also served as a place for scholars to gather and study.
4. **Metropolitan examination (会试)** - The second level of imperial examinations in ancient China, held in the capital.
5. **Qi Kingdom (岐国)** - A fictional kingdom mentioned as being more progressive regarding women's rights.
6. **Qi Yunlou (戚云楼)** - Su Mo's childhood friend and neighbor, a progressive woman scholar attempting to enter government service.
7. **"Wildfire cannot burn it all, spring wind blows and it grows again" (野火烧不尽，春风吹又生)** - A famous line from a classical Chinese poem by Bai Juyi, describing the resilience of grass and by extension, the human spirit.